



INCULCATE!

Raising him right!

P&C's guide to bringing up your child as a spiritual
and secular individual...

Words Pallavi Bhattacharya

Various religious beliefs and practices exist in India. Our country, as per the declaration in the Preamble to the Indian Constitution, is a secular nation. To raise children who love and respect all faiths and imbibe a spiritual personality; is not just the task of our schools but indeed the

greatest responsibility of this lies with the parents. So, how can you go about doing this?

BE A ROLE MODEL

First and foremost, to raise a spiritual and secular child, you need to possess the very attributes. You simply can't

expect your child to tread on a holistic path by setting a bad example. Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Dayal Mirchandani points out, "Children have a hypocrisy detector, which is why you should practice what you preach. For instance, if you smoke but dissuade your kids from doing so, they will feel that you are implying that there is nothing wrong with it. Similarly, you cannot be unkind and expect your kids to be kind to others."

LOVE FOR ALL

Dr Mirchandani also points out that parents need to inculcate a love for



Aarti Gupta

humanity to raise a spiritual and secular offspring. Mumbai-based psychologist and Reiki master Aarti Gupta advises, "We should

not criticise other faiths in front of our kids. Instead, we should celebrate festivals of all faiths with equal fervour, simultaneously explaining to them the spiritual significance of each festival. Also, we should not admit them to a school which enforces a particular religious ideology in a dogmatic way."

Antara Mukhopadhyay, who teaches in Panchasayar Sishu Niketan in Kolkata, is a devotee of Swami Vivekananda and Ramakrishna Paramahansa, both of whom believed that different religions are various roads which lead to the same God. She has inculcated the same liberal and secular outlook in her 10-year-old son Dibyashankar Mukhopadhyay. She elaborates, "I encourage my child to have friends of various religions."

Gurgaon-based home maker Niti Tandon, mum to Aryan, eight, and



Antara Mukhopadhyay

Neil, three, adds, "I taught my sons how the British had used the strategy of 'divide and rule' to segregate Hindus from Muslims for their own personal

motive and how we are all one and belong to the same family of God."

Following Niti's style of mentoring, you should tell your child that Mahatma Gandhi preached '*Ishwar Allah tero*



naam, sab ko sanmati de bhagwan?
(God and Allah are Your names, Bless everyone with real wisdom, Lord)' while he and his followers sang 'Raghupati Raghav Raja Ram' during Independence missions. Gandhiji brought freedom to India by bringing together Indians of all religions to fight against the British. You should explain to your child that, for a united India, having a secular outlook is mandatory.

You may read out books of all faiths and religions to your tot. It is also a



good idea to sing hymns of all religions at bedtime and encourage him to learn prayers of myriad faiths. Instead of making spiritual education pedantic or overtly religious, you may add an

element of fun to it. For instance, if your kid is interested in art and craft, he may be encouraged to make a scrapbook with pictures and notes on various religions of India.

During weekends, instead of only visiting malls and parties with your child; you could take him to yoga and meditation classes, talks for kids on spirituality and visits to charitable homes where he can help you with some social work. Vacations may include pilgrimages to various places of worship and spiritual centres.

SPIRITUAL EQ

If your child has great knowledge on matters of spirituality but is angry, restless, disobedient, rude and cruel; he isn't the least bit spiritual. A truly spiritual child is calm, composed, obedient and kind.

Antara candidly confesses, "When my son was in nursery, I would hear complaints from teachers that he was restless and got into fights. To discipline him, I taught him to meditate. In the evening, when I would light candles and incense sticks in my spiritual corner, I would persuade him to sit calmly in meditation. Soon, he was transformed into a peaceful, compliant and compassionate child."

COUNTERING PEER PRESSURE

Truly spiritual children may be a microscopic minority. The greater fraction of the world's population will not score too high on the spiritual quotient. Many of your child's friends may make fun of his spiritual nature and insist that reading books on spirituality and attending religious discourses is highly uncool. They may mislead him that it's better not to take spirituality and academics seriously and that he

should rather spend more time on computer games.

Dr Mirchandani advises, "You should teach your child to select his friends carefully and avoid discussing his spiritual pursuits with classmates who don't believe in it. Instead, he may discuss his spiritual hobbies with the kids of the same meditation group that he attends."



If you raise a confident child with high self-esteem, he will not be confused if his peers insist that he should abandon his spiritual ways. For

instance, Dibyashankar simply wasn't led astray when his friends jeered at him for being spiritual. Antara explains, "My son boldly ignored all the friends who taunted him saying that he would become a *sadhu*."

ALLOW KIDS TO BE FREE THINKERS

Instead of forcibly inoculating religious do's and don'ts into your child, encourage him to have a thinking mind. Appreciate it when he raises various questions on God, Satan, angels, demons, life, death, religion, spirituality, birth, rebirth, sin, virtue, heaven and hell. Accept it even when he debates on religious matters. Remain composed even if he contradicts your religious beliefs.

Especially, as your child grows up, he may develop his own spiritual beliefs and also embark on a spiritual quest. It is not mandatory that he will necessarily exactly follow your religious beliefs. Live and let live is relevant to all aspects of life, including your child's chosen spiritual path.

DO NOT OVER-DO IT

An excess of anything is bad. If you make it compulsory that your child has to pray at least half a dozen times a day and isn't allowed to watch TV, attend birthday parties, visit pizza and burger outlets and read no literature outside your ideology fearing that your child will go down in his spiritual nature if given any freedom whatsoever; it will be seriously detrimental to him.

Aarti cautions, "In the case of a spiritual overdose, not only will your child not feel connected to spirituality but will get exhausted by it." Dr Dayal seconds her, "Forcing is not the least bit spiritual. In a scenario like, this rebellion is likely, especially when the child enters his teens."

What can be worse is that your child may imbibe traits that counter spirituality in a dictatorship environment like this. If forcibly completely kept away from something natural, he may do that in secret.

Niti has learnt through experience

not to be over-strict. "There was a time when I was against my children watching television and playing games on the Internet. As rightfully opined, the more you resist, the more it persists. My elder son started spending time at my neighbour's house, where he had access to both television and games. I have become more flexible now. He has opened an e-mail account after getting our approval at the age of eight and is happy and content in exchanging e-mails with his friends and grandfather."

Antara also tries her level best to keep a balance while raising a spiritual child. After all, she wouldn't ideally like her son to become an ascetic who leaves home! She elaborates, "I explain to my child that he can serve God by staying on in worldly life. For instance, if he grows up to be a doctor; he will be doing God's work while serving mankind, the poor and needy. Having said that, if he later wishes to be a wandering monk; he has the right to do so, as I cannot claim complete control on his spiritual life and future." **P&C**

